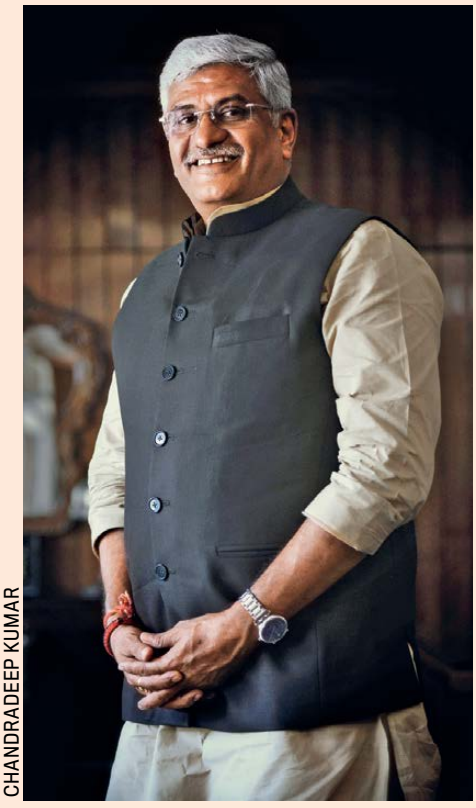
GAJENDRA SINGH SHEKHAWAT, *56* | BJP
Minister of Tourism; Culture

TOURISM; CULTURE



CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

All-rounder A third-time MP from Jodhpur in Rajasthan, Shekhawat was born to a government officer father in Jaisalmer. An ABVP member, he was elected his university's student union president in 1992. Also played basketball at national level

Big wins In 2014, Shekhawat achieved a record-winning margin (410,000-plus votes) in Jodhpur. After serving as MoS in Modi's first tenure, he was elevated as cabinet minister of Jal Shakti—nodal ministry for Har Ghar Jal—in 2019, perhaps in recognition of his win over then Rajasthan CM Ashok Gehlot's son

Minister of State (Tourism)



SURESH GOPI , *65* | BJP

Grand debut The actor-turned-neta is the BJP's first ever Lok Sabha MP from Kerala. Elected from Thrissur, he was earlier a nominated Rajya Sabha MP (2016-22)

Minister of State (Culture)



RAO INDERJIT SINGH, *74* | BJP

Old hand A six-time MP with royal lineage, he represents Gurgaon. Has also been given independent charge of the ministries of planning and statistics & programme implementation

REALISING THE TRUE POTENTIAL

Conserving and promoting India's rich heritage can generate jobs and spur other sectors too

By KAUSHIK DEKA

Emerging from the shadow of Covid-19, India saw a 64 per cent growth in foreign tourist arrivals in 2023, thanks to several government initiatives promoting tourism and enhancing connectivity. However, India still lags behind European, American and even East Asian destinations in most-visited countries worldwide.

The World Travel and Tourism Council forecasts the sector to increase its GDP contribution to $15.5 trillion by 2033, representing 11.6 per cent of the global economy and employing almost 12 per cent of the working population. It's imperative that the tourism ministry helps India claim its share of this global pie.

The culture ministry also plays a key role in attracting tourists by showcasing India's vast diversity through festivals, museums and historical monuments. But it has traditionally been crippled by low budgetary allocations. ■

WHAT NEEDS TO BE DONE

SINGLE-WINDOW NOD Stakeholders have long demanded industry status for tourism. Better inter-departmental coordination along with single-window clearance for faster approvals and licences will help

NATIONAL POLICY India needs a National Tourism Policy, making the sector a national priority. It should also be moved to the concurrent list from the state list for greater Centre-state synergy

TARGET NEW MARKETS The Incredible India campaign needs an urgent makeover, with a renewed focus on tourism promotion in 20 key source markets besides 10 emerging markets for India. To achieve this, overseas tourism promotion offices should be reopened